CLEO · AI GUIDES

AI for Musicians

The complete guide to AI tools for guitarists, producers, and music lovers — with step-by-step exercises you can follow today.

Suno · Moises · ChordAI · Hooktheory · iZotope RX · LANDR · Splice · Neutron 4

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INTRODUCTION

AI Has Arrived in Music. Here's What's Actually Worth Using.

The hype around AI in music is enormous and mostly unhelpful. Half the tools being promoted are gimmicks. The other half are genuinely useful but poorly explained. This guide cuts through both.

Every exercise in this guide includes exact steps — where to click, what to type, what to listen for. You shouldn't have to guess. Open the tool on your phone or laptop as you read, follow the steps, and actually hear the result. That's the point.

One thing upfront: AI won't make you a better musician. It removes friction and handles tedious technical tasks. Your ears, your taste, and your feel are still entirely yours.

How to use this guide

- Keep your phone or laptop open alongside this guide. Do the exercises as you read.
- Don't try all eight tools at once. Pick one, use it for a week, then come back.
- Every tool here has a free tier. You don't need to pay anything to try any exercise.
- Screenshots in this guide show you exactly what to look for on screen.

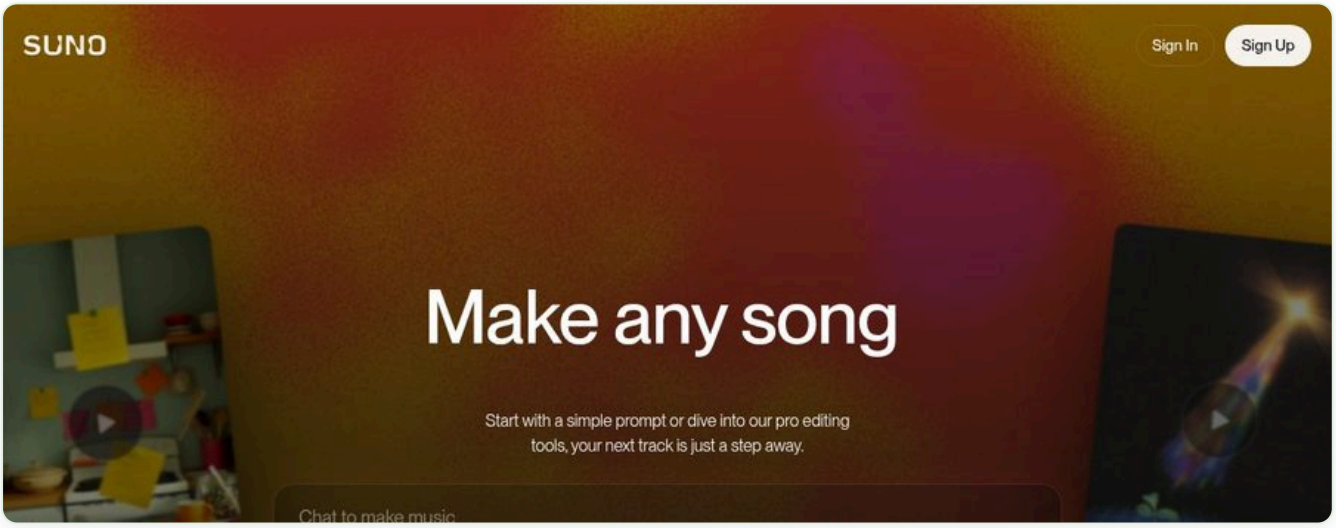
8	35+	$0	3hrs
Tools covered in depth	Step-by-step exercises	To try every exercise	Estimated weekly time saved

01 MUSIC GENERATION

Suno

Describe a song in plain English — hear it in 30 seconds

Free · Pro $8/month suno.com



The Suno interface — the prompt box is in the centre. Type your description and click Create.

Suno generates complete songs — vocals, instrumentation, production — from a plain-English description. You're not using it for finished tracks. The value is speed: an idea that takes 20 minutes to demo on an instrument takes 30 seconds in Suno.

What it's excellent at

→ **Reference tracks.** Hear your chord progression as a full production in a different genre. Faster than any other method.

→ **Breaking writer's block.** Generate 10 variations of an idea in 10 minutes. One will spark something.

→ **Genre exploration.** Want to understand why a reggae groove feels the way it does? Generate one and listen analytically.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 The genre mashup (10 minutes)

1. Go to **suno.com** in your browser. Click **Create** in the left sidebar.
2. In the prompt box, type a specific description: *"Driving rock song, 120bpm, distorted Marshall amp tone, anthemic chorus, feels like early 2000s alternative"*. Be specific — vague prompts give generic results.
3. Click the **Create** button. Two versions will generate in about 30 seconds.
4. Listen to both. Note: what works? What doesn't? The production style, the groove, the energy level.
5. Click **Reuse Prompt**, change one word (e.g. "driving" to "melancholic"), generate again. Hear how one word shifts the whole feel.

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2 Build a production reference for a song you're working on

1. Think of a song you're currently writing or demoing. What production style do you want? Pick a reference artist or describe the sound in 2–3 words (e.g. "warm indie folk, fingerpicked acoustic, close-mic vocals").
2. Open Suno, click **Create**, and describe your target sound as precisely as you can. Include: tempo feel (slow/mid/driving), instruments, mood, any genre terms.
3. Generate 3–4 versions with slight prompt variations.
4. Choose the one closest to your vision. Leave it playing in the background as you work on your own recording — use it as a reference for mix decisions, arrangement density, and overall vibe.
5. This replaces 20 minutes of hunting through Spotify for a reference that's "close but not quite".

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3 The unexpected genre experiment — ear training in disguise

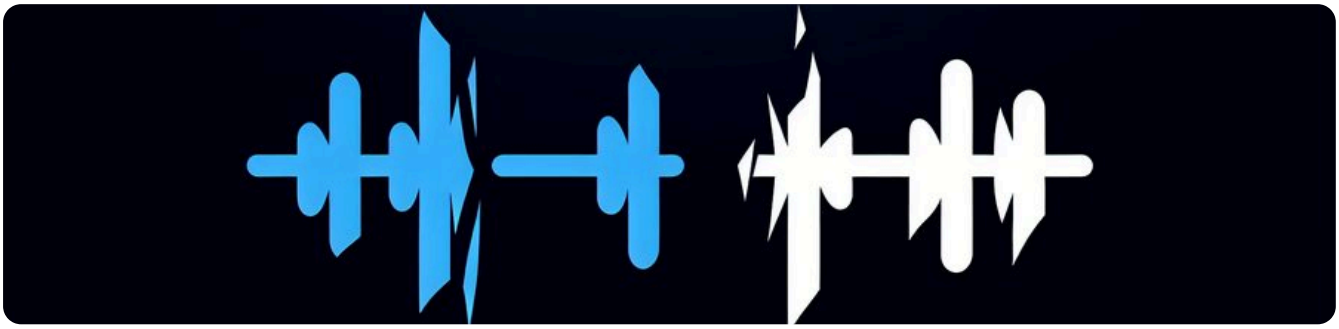
1. Pick a song you know well. Note its key (or approximate it — major/minor is enough).
2. In Suno, type: *"[your song title] reimagined as [completely different genre], same chord progression, [key]"*. E.g. "Wonderwall as bossa nova, minor key, guitar and upright bass".
3. Listen to the output. What melodic or harmonic elements survived the genre change? What got lost?
4. Ask yourself: why does this chord progression work in bossa nova but feel different in the original? This question — pursued honestly — is 20 minutes of effective ear training.

Bottom line: Start here. Free tier gives you enough generations per day to evaluate it properly. Use it for ideas and references, not finished products. Upgrade to Pro ($8/month) when you're using it daily.

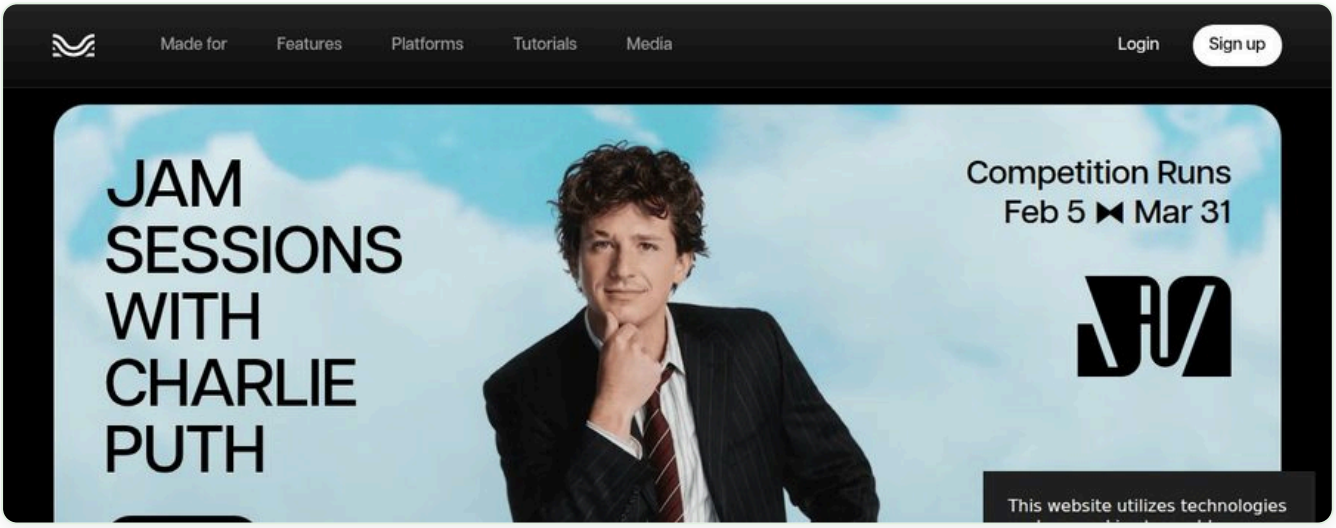
02 PRACTICE & LEARNING

Moises

The best practice tool since the metronome — separate any song into stems instantly



Free (limited) · Premium $3.99/month moises.ai



The Moises interface — upload a song or paste a YouTube link, then use the stem controls to mute/solo individual instruments.

Moises separates any song into stems (vocals, drums, bass, other) and lets you slow it down without changing pitch, transpose to any key, and mute specific parts. This changes how you practise entirely.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 Learn a difficult song section (the right way)

1. Go to **moises.ai** and sign up for the free account. Click **Add Music**.
2. You can upload an MP3, or paste a **YouTube URL** directly. Paste the URL of a song with a section you've been struggling with. Processing takes 1–3 minutes.
3. Once processed, click the song. You'll see stems: Vocals, Drums, Bass, Other (instruments). Click the **speaker icon** next to your instrument (e.g. "Other" for guitar) to **mute it**.
4. Use the **speed slider** to set playback to **60%**. Find the difficult section using the waveform timeline and click **loop** to loop those bars.
5. Play along with the rest of the band at slow speed until clean. Move to 80%, then 100%. This single workflow replaces every other transcription method.

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2 Create an instant backing track for your practice session

1. In Moises, upload (or link) one of your favourite songs to jam to.
2. Once processed, **mute the stem that matches your instrument** — guitar players mute "Other", bass players mute "Bass", drummers mute "Drums".
3. Hit play and play along. You're now playing with the real rhythm section from a professional recording.
4. Use the **key transpose** control (the musical note icon) to move the song to a more comfortable key if needed. You can shift up or down by semitone.
5. Do this for 3 songs in a row. Notice the difference in your engagement compared to playing to a metronome or a backing track app.

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3 Analyse a bass line or drum groove you've always half-heard

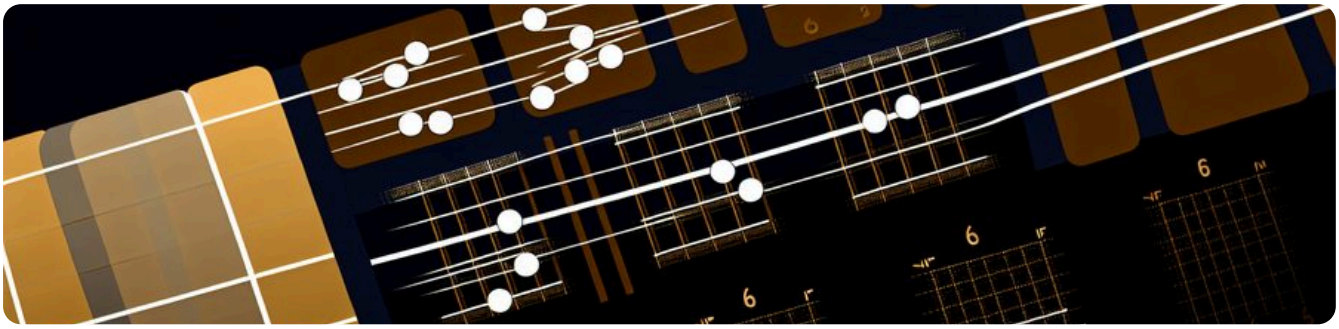
1. Upload a song with a bass line or drum groove you find interesting but have never fully understood.
2. Mute all stems *except* the one you want to study (Bass or Drums). Solo it by clicking the ear icon, or mute all others.
3. Listen through from the start at full speed. Then slow to 70% and listen again.
4. Pay attention to: *where does the bass note land relative to the beat? Does it anticipate or land on the downbeat? What rhythmic pattern is the bass playing against the kick drum?*
5. Try to play or sing what you hear. Even if you're not a bassist, understanding this makes you a better musician.

Bottom line: The single highest-value tool in this guide for practising musicians. $4/month is negligible. If you subscribe to only one tool, make it this one.

03 CHORD RECOGNITION

ChordAI

Point your phone at any song — see the chords appear in real time



Free · Pro $4.99/month chord.ai (app store)

ChordAI is a **smartphone app** (iOS and Android) that listens to any song playing through your speakers and displays the chords in real time on a guitar fretboard or piano keyboard as they change. Accuracy is around 85–90% for standard progressions in common genres.

Getting set up

- → Search **"ChordAI"** in the App Store or Google Play. Download the free version.
- → Open the app — you'll see a guitar neck display and a large microphone button at the bottom.
- → The app uses your phone's microphone to hear music playing nearby. Play music through a speaker (not headphones) and the chords will appear as the song plays.
- → Alternatively, tap **Import** to upload an audio file directly from your phone.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 Learn the chords of a song you've been avoiding

1. Download ChordAI from your app store. Open it — you'll see a guitar neck (or piano) display with a large
   Record
   button at the bottom.
2. Play the song through a Bluetooth speaker or your phone's speaker (not headphones — the app needs to hear the audio).
3. Tap the
   Record
   button in ChordAI. As the song plays, watch the chord name update in real time at the top of the screen. The fretboard shows you exactly where to put your fingers.
4. Pause the song at any chord that changes quickly. The last detected chord stays on screen. Note it down.
5. Once you have the full progression, play through it on your guitar using the fingering shown. Then play the song again and verify each chord with your ear. The AI gets you 85% of the way; your ear does the rest.

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2 Your ear vs. the AI — an honest diagnostic

1. Pick a song you already know reasonably well. Before opening ChordAI, listen to the verse and chorus and write down your best guess at the chord progression on paper.
2. Now run the song through ChordAI. Compare its output to your written guess.
3. For every chord where you disagree with ChordAI, listen back carefully. Is your ear right, or is the AI right? (Sometimes both. Sometimes neither.)
4. Identify the *type* of chords you tend to miss — suspended chords? Minor 7ths? Substitutions? This pattern tells you exactly what ear training to focus on next.

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3 Build your genre harmonic blueprint for songwriting

1. Pick 3 songs from a genre you want to write in. Run each through ChordAI and write down: the key, the full chord progression of verse and chorus, and any chords that feel "surprising" or interesting.
2. Compare your 3 progressions side by side. What keys do they use most? What chords appear in all 3? What's the typical verse-to-chorus harmonic movement?
3. You now have a genre harmonic template. Use it deliberately in your next composition — start with these patterns, then deviate from them intentionally for effect.

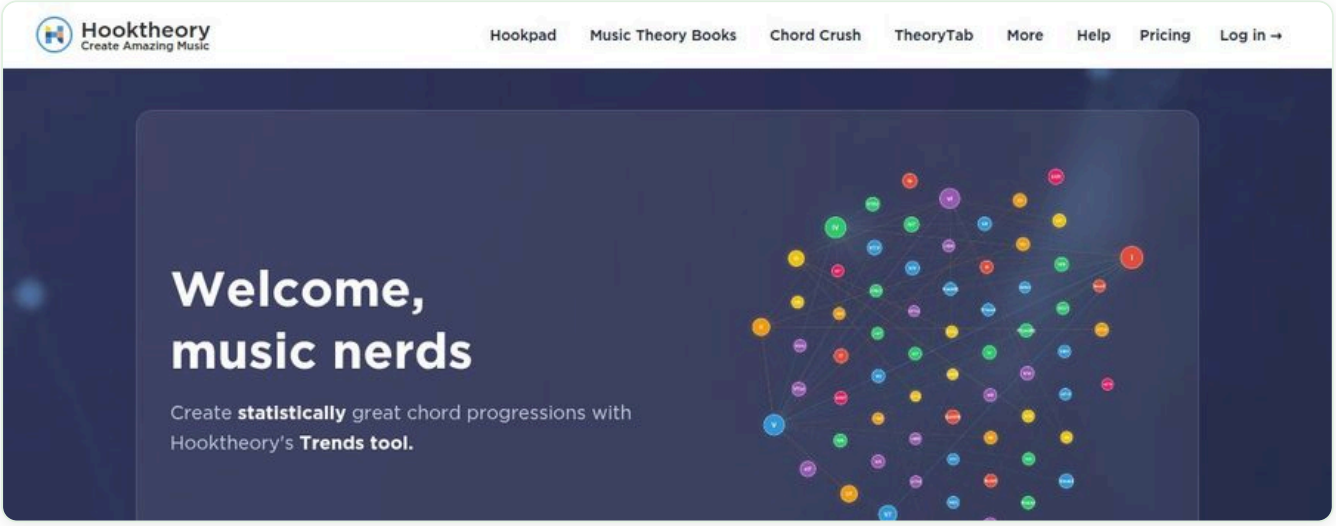
Bottom line: An essential tool for any guitarist who learns by ear. Always verify what ChordAI tells you against your own ear — that process is ear training in itself. Pro ($5/month) adds unlimited usage and YouTube link analysis.

04 MUSIC THEORY

Hooktheory

Understand why the chord progressions you love actually work

Free to browse · Pro $9.99/month hooktheory.com



Hooktheory Trends — search any chord progression and see every famous song that uses it, with playback.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 Discover what songs share your favourite chord progression

1. Go to **hooktheory.com/trends** in your browser. No account needed.
2. You'll see chord buttons labelled I, II, III, IV, V, VI, VII (Roman numerals = scale degrees). Click the chords that make up a progression you love. E.g. for "I-V-vi-IV" (the most common pop progression), click I, then V, then vi, then IV.
3. As you click each chord, a list of matching songs appears on the right. Scroll through it — you'll recognise dozens of songs you know well.
4. Click any song title to open it. Hit **Play** to hear the progression highlighted in the sheet music as it plays. Notice how the same chords produce completely different emotional results depending on tempo, rhythm, and melody.
5. This is music theory made audible. The chords are abstract until you hear them in context.

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2 Write a chord progression using Hookpad — with theory guidance

1. Go to **hooktheory.com/hookpad**. Sign up for a free account if prompted.
2. At the top, set your **key** (e.g. C major) and your **time signature** (4/4 is standard).
3. Click on chord slots to add chords. As you hover over each Roman numeral option, Hookpad shows you the probability of that chord appearing next in songs — based on thousands of real songs in that key.
4. Build an 8-bar progression. Click **Play** at any time to hear what you've written. Try changing one chord to something with a lower probability — something unexpected. Listen to how it creates tension or surprise.
5. When you have something you like, try adding a melody by clicking the melody track. Even a simple 4-note melody over your chords will reveal whether the progression actually works.

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3 Analyse the pre-chorus of a song you love — understand tension and release

1. Find a song with a pre-chorus that really builds tension before the chorus hits. (Examples: "Don't Stop Believin'" by Journey, "Mr. Brightside" by The Killers, almost any pop song with a "lift" before the big chorus.)
2. Use ChordAI or look up the chords, then enter them into Hookpad.
3. Look at which Roman numerals the pre-chorus uses. You'll often find chords like the II, the IV, or the VI — chords that are harmonically "away from home" and create a feeling of suspension.
4. Notice how the chorus almost always starts with the I chord — the "home" chord. The pre-chorus built tension by moving away from it; the chorus releases that tension by returning. Apply this deliberately in your own writing.

Bottom line: Free browsing of Trends is enough to get serious value. Pro unlocks Hookpad's full features — worth it if you're actively composing. Use alongside ChordAI: ChordAI tells you what the chords are; Hooktheory tells you why they work.

05 AUDIO REPAIR

iZotope RX

The most practically useful studio AI tool — salvages recordings you thought were ruined

Elements $99 (on sale regularly) · Standard $399 izotope.com/rx

iZotope RX uses machine learning to separate audio into components and remove problems. It works as a standalone app and as plugins inside your DAW (Logic, Pro Tools, Ableton, Reaper, etc).

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 Rescue a recording with background noise

1. Go to **izotope.com/rx** and download the **free trial** of RX Elements. Install it and open the standalone RX application (not your DAW plugin yet).
2. Go to **File → Open** and load a recording you've been unhappy with — ideally one with consistent background noise (room hum, traffic, fan noise).
3. You'll see the audio as a waveform and a spectrogram (colourful frequency display). The spectrogram shows noise as a consistent layer across the bottom of the image.
4. In the left panel, click **Dialogue De-noise** (or **De-noise**). Click **Learn** and play the audio for 2–3 seconds where only the background noise is present (no voice/instrument). RX learns the noise profile.
5. Click **Process**. The noise is removed. Hit **Play** and compare to the original using the **A/B button** at the top. The difference is usually dramatic.

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2 Remove mouth clicks from a vocal recording

1. Open a vocal recording in RX. Listen carefully on headphones — you'll hear small clicks, lip smacks, or breath sounds between phrases that you never noticed in the session.
2. In the left panel, select **De-click**. Set the mode to **Multi-band** and the strength to around **3–4** (gentle).
3. Select the entire file (Ctrl/Cmd + A) and click **Process**.
4. Listen back on headphones. The clicks should be gone or significantly reduced without affecting the natural sound of the voice.
5. This step is often skipped but always audible in the mix. Clean vocals sit further forward and sound more professional without any EQ or compression changes.

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3 Study a professional mix by separating it into stems

1. In RX, go to
   File → Open
   and load a commercially released song you want to learn from production-wise.
2. In the left panel, find
   Music Rebalance
   . This separates the mix into: Vocals, Bass, Drums, Other.
3. Turn the
   Bass gain slider
   up to +12dB and everything else to -12dB. Hit play. You're now listening to just the bass in isolation.
4. Listen carefully: What notes does the bass play? Does it follow the kick drum or play against it? What's the rhythmic relationship? How much sustain does each note have?
5. Repeat for drums, then vocals. You'll hear production details you've never noticed despite knowing the song for years.

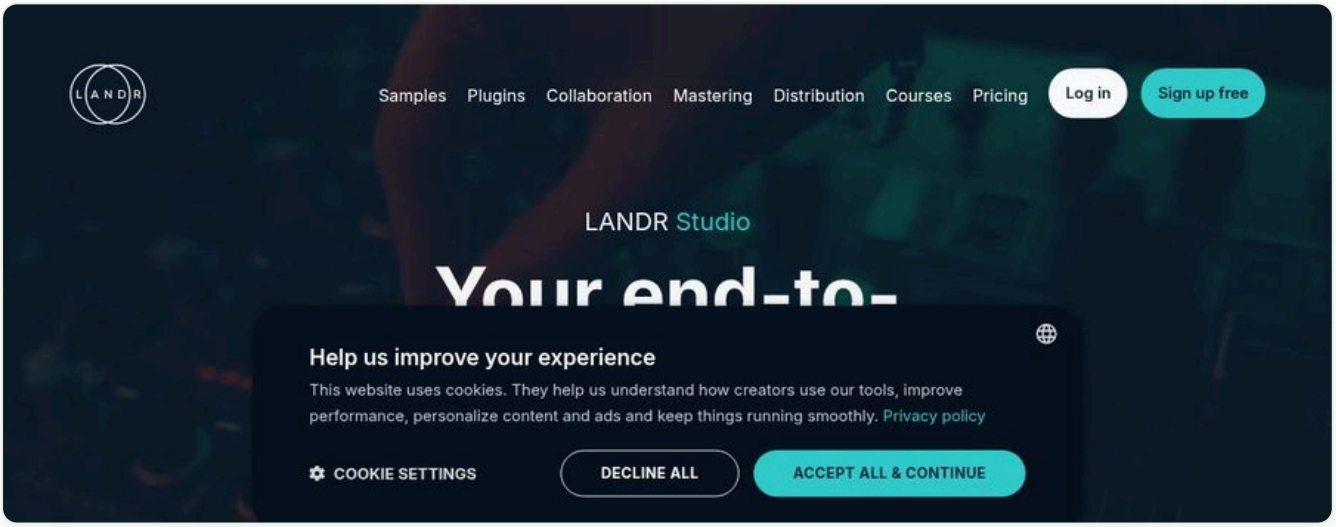
Bottom line: Elements ($99, frequently 50% off) pays for itself the first time it saves a performance you'd otherwise re-record. Check izotope.com for sale pricing — it goes on sale several times a year.

06 MASTERING

LANDR

AI mastering in minutes — honest about what it is and what it isn't

Free (watermarked) · Basic $8.99/month landr.com



LANDR's upload interface — drag your mix file here. After processing (under 2 minutes), you can compare the master to your original and download.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 Master your mix and use the result as a diagnostic

1. Go to **landr.com** and sign up for a free account.
2. Export your mix from your DAW as a **WAV file at 24-bit, 44.1kHz** (this is the standard for mastering submission). Do not apply a limiter to your mix bus — give LANDR headroom to work with.
3. On LANDR's dashboard, click **Upload a track** and drag your WAV file in. Processing takes 60–90 seconds.
4. When done, LANDR shows you the mastered file with a waveform. Click the **Compare** button to A/B between your original mix and the mastered version.
5. As you A/B, listen for: *Where does LANDR add brightness? Where does it tighten the low end? Where does it pull back harshness?* Write down 3 specific things. These are your mix's weak points — fix them in your DAW before your next session.

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2 Test different mastering styles

1. On the mastered track page, look for the **Mastering Style** options: Low, Medium, High intensity (and sometimes genre-specific presets).
2. Download the master at Medium intensity. Then change to Low and download again. Then High.
3. Import all three into your DAW or a listening app and A/B them at the same volume level. Which sits closest to commercial references in your genre?
4. The "right" setting is the one that sounds most like the professional releases you're competing with in playlists. Trust your ears, not the label.

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3 The one-day demo challenge

1. Set a timer for 8 hours. Your goal: write, record, mix, and LANDR-master a complete demo within it.
2. Use Suno to generate a quick production reference (15 minutes). Record your demo (whatever time remains after writing). Mix quickly — don't obsess.
3. Export, upload to LANDR, download the master.
4. Listen to the finished master. What's actually there? What does the time pressure force you to decide? This exercise — done quarterly — reveals how fast you can actually work when you remove perfectionism from the equation.

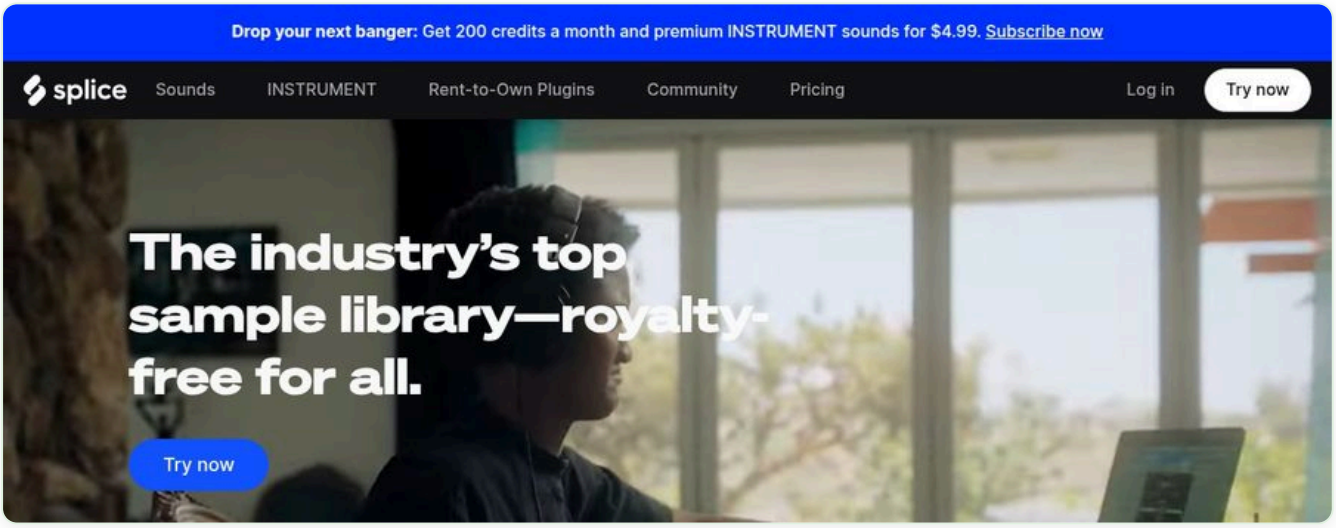
Bottom line: Use LANDR for demos, social media, and mix diagnostics. Don't use it for commercial releases — get a human mastering engineer for those. Free tier (watermarked) is enough to evaluate whether it works for your workflow.

07 SAMPLES & SOUNDS

Splice

The world's largest sample library — with AI search that finds what you're hearing in your head

Free to browse · Sounds from $7.99/month splice.com



Splice's browse interface — use the AI search bar at the top. Type descriptive language ("dark moody piano loop at 90bpm") rather than just keyword tags.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 Use AI search to find sounds by vibe, not by keyword

1. Go to
   splice.com
   and sign up for a free account. Click
   Sounds
   in the top navigation.
2. In the search bar, type a descriptive phrase rather than a keyword: try *"melancholic piano loop with lots of space and reverb"* or *"punchy hip hop kick with grit and weight"*.
3. Browse the results. Click any sample to preview it. If you like it, click
   +
   to add it to your cart (you'll need a subscription to download, but previewing is free).
4. Now search the same category with a basic keyword: *"piano loop"* or *"kick drum"*. Compare the quality and relevance of results. The AI search finds sounds that match a *feeling*; keyword search just matches labels.
5. This is the most important difference Splice has made — it's how producers actually think when looking for sounds.

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2 Build a session from a curated sound palette

1. Before opening your DAW, spend 20 minutes on Splice finding 6–8 samples that feel like they belong together. They should all have a similar mood, even if the instruments are different.
2. Download them all (or note the names to download when you subscribe). Import them all into a fresh DAW session.
3. Set a tempo that feels right for the sounds. Don't use a click — let the sounds dictate the groove.
4. Arrange the samples. See what emerges. The constraint of working from a fixed, curated palette forces creative decisions you wouldn't make starting from blank.
5. This approach — sound-first composition — is how many professional producers work. The sounds suggest the track, rather than the track demanding specific sounds.

Bottom line: Essential for producers in sample-based genres. The AI search alone justifies the subscription if you spend time hunting for sounds. Browse freely before subscribing — preview everything first.

08 MIXING

Neutron 4

AI mixing assistant — gets your session to a working starting point in 10 minutes instead of an hour

$149 (on sale regularly) izotope.com/neutron

Neutron works inside your DAW as a plugin on individual tracks, and as a system-level tool through the Mix Assistant feature. It analyses all your tracks playing together and creates an initial mix balance automatically. The suggestions are starting points — the AI gets you to 60–70% of a good mix; the rest is your taste and skill.

⚡ Try This — Step-by-Step Exercises

1 Run the Mix Assistant on a session you've already mixed

1. With Neutron installed, open a session you've mixed manually. In your DAW, open the **Neutron Mix Assistant**

   (in Logic: look for it in the plug-in menu; in Ableton: add it to your Master or a group track; in Pro Tools: open from the multi-mono plug-in list).
2. Click **Get Started**

   . Neutron will ask you to play your session for 10–15 seconds. Hit play in your DAW and let it listen.
3. After analysis, Neutron shows suggested fader positions for every track. **Don't apply them yet.**

   First, compare them to your current mix levels.
4. Identify the 3 biggest differences between Neutron's suggestions and your mix. For each: why does Neutron want it louder/quieter? Listen to the track in context and decide who's right.
5. This comparison is more instructive than just applying the mix — it shows you where your instincts differ from an objective analysis.

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2 Use Unmask on kick and bass — hear the difference immediately

1. Load Neutron as a plugin on your **kick drum track**

   . Inside Neutron, click the **Unmask**

   tab.
2. Click **Add Masking Track**

   and select your **bass track**

   . Neutron now analyses how these two tracks compete in the same frequency range.
3. Play your session. Neutron will automatically apply frequency cuts to each track to make space for the other — a slight dip in the bass where the kick lives, and vice versa.
4. A/B before and after using the bypass button. Listen specifically to the **kick punch**

   — can you hear it more clearly through the bass? On headphones, the difference is usually obvious.
5. If it sounds over-processed, reduce the **Unmask Sensitivity**

   slider. If it sounds too subtle, increase it. Trust your ears.

Bottom line: Buy on sale (check izotope.com — 50–70% off sales happen regularly). The Unmask feature alone is worth the cost if you mix anything with kick and bass together. It's a starting-point accelerator, not a finished mix.

BRINGING IT TOGETHER

Your AI Studio Workflow

A complete end-to-end workflow from idea to finished demo. Pick the stages that match where you actually get stuck.

1

SUNO

Idea generation (10 min)

Generate 5–10 concepts in Suno. Listen for any element that excites you — a chord, rhythm, texture. Screenshot the prompt that produced it. You're not using the output; you're using it to find creative direction.

2

CHORDAI + HOOKTHEORY

Harmony development (15 min)

Run your reference song through ChordAI to get the chord framework. Use Hooktheory Trends to understand why it works and explore variations. Now you have a harmonic starting point you understand, not just one you've copied.

3

MOISES

Production deconstruction (20 min)

Use Moises to strip apart your production reference into stems. Listen to isolated drums, bass, guitars. Build a mental model of the production before you start recording.

4

IZOTOPE RX

Recording and repair

Record your demo. Afterwards: De-noise all recordings, De-click all vocals. Fix problems before they reach the mix — every minute spent here saves three in the mix.

5

NEUTRON 4 + SPLICE

Mix starting point

Run Mix Assistant for initial balance. Use Unmask on kick and bass. Use Splice to fill sound design gaps. Then mix with your ears — the AI has done the groundwork.

6

LANDR

Demo master (5 min)

Upload to LANDR for a quick master. Use the A/B comparison as a diagnostic for your next mix session. For demos and social content, the LANDR master is ready to share.

WHAT'S NEXT

Where to Go From Here

You now have tools, context, and step-by-step exercises. The one thing that separates musicians who find AI genuinely useful from those who don't is simple: they actually do the exercises instead of just reading about them.

Start with **Moises** — it's $4/month and the value is immediate. If you record at home, add iZotope RX next. Everything else can follow in whatever order matches your workflow.

AI doesn't replace the musical knowledge, taste, and feel you've built over years. It removes the friction between you and your ideas — so more of them make it into finished music.

More guides from Cleo

This is part of a series of practical AI guides. If you found this useful, the AI Starter Guide covers 9 essential AI tools for everyday life — same depth, same step-by-step format.

More guides
cleoops.com

Questions?
hello@cleoops.com

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